Clinton invited both prime ministers to the White House in early July, but only Sharif accepted the invitation, flying into Washington on 4 July. Clinton told him in no uncertain terms that unless Pakistan pulled all of its troops back from the Line of Control in Kargil and kept them out of the Indian bunkers, the United States would not be able to stop India from "escalating" the war. Sharif got the message and flew home to order Musharraf to keep his forces clear of the Line of Control and never to send any more soldiers up there without prior approval from his prime minister. An immediate cease-fire put an end to the Kargil war on 16 July 1999, defusing any potential nuclear escalation.

Musharraf never forgave Sharif for his "cowardice" in surrendering to U.S. pressure over Kargil, but he waited until 12 October before launching his coup to remove the prime minister from office on grounds of treason. In a memoir he published seven years later, Musharraf insisted that Sharif had launched a "coup" against *him*, referring to his own military coup as a "countercoup."[4] Musharraf charged Nawaz with attempting to murder him by denying the pilot of a plane in which he was flying home from Sri Lanka permission to land at Karachi airport. Musharraf's troops had then seized the airport, bringing their COAS home. Prime Minister Sharif was instantly arrested, tried, and found guilty by a kangaroo court, which sentenced him to death. More sensitive than Zia ul-Haq had been to international appeals for clemency, however, Musharraf permitted Sharif to fly off to Saudi Arabia with his family, after he had agreed not to run for any elective office again for at least ten years.

Musharraf first proclaimed himself chief executive of Pakistan, feeling perhaps that this was a more appealing title than chief martial law administrator. But he soon replaced it with president, while keeping his COAS rank, the true key to his power. Unlike Zia, Musharraf was neither an Islamic fundamentalist nor a religious zealot. He claimed that he was simply a good soldier and had seized power merely to clean up the civil political "corruption" that had plunged Pakistan into virtual bankruptcy. He insisted, moreover, as Ayub and Zia had before him, that he was eager to return to his job of soldiering, having "no interest" in politics. Initially, most Pakistanis believed Musharraf and admired him for trying to save their poor nation from totally collapsing after a decade of political floundering under Benazir Bhutto and Nawaz Sharif, who kept replacing each other as prime minister while failing to fix the economy or improve the lot of their people.